

NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

Each Deal shows only your hand during the Bidding pages. You are asked to decide what bid/call you would make for the hand and when you have decided you click **BID** to go to the next page where the recommended bid is shown with any appropriate comments. This continues throughout the Bidding section, and when the final bid is made your partner's hand is also shown.

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table. When you have the Plan in your mind, click **NEXT** to go to the next page.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer. When that happens a page will appear for you to click **ROTATE** to switch the hands so South becomes the Declarer. It is important to note that on this page the complete Bidding Auction is also rotated to correspond with South being Declarer. So if something in the plan depends upon the bidding this is the page to look at, not the earlier bidding pages.

The final page shows the full deal, including the East/West hands.

You may use the left Navigation panel to go to any numbered Deal you like, or you may just go to the next Deal by clicking the link at the bottom of the last page of a Deal.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.

1NT Opening: 15-17 points

2NT Opening: 20-21 points

1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit

2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

There is Stayman lesson on BakerBridge which can be reached by clicking Home on the menubar.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.

In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

There is a Jacoby Transfer lesson you can access by clicking Home.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.

Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

There is a lebensohl lesson you can access by clicking Home.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

Board: 1

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: North

Lead: ♠K

Board: 2

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3♠

Declarer: East

Lead: ♦J

Board: 3

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: South

Lead: ♦Q

Board: 4

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: West

Lead: ♥5

Board: 5

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠

Declarer: North

Lead: ♥K

Board 1

East Deals

None Vul

♠ 7 3
♥ J 10 8 5
♦ J 6
♣ Q 10 8 7 3

♠ A 10 9
♥ K Q 6 4
♦ A 9 5 2
♣ A 5



♠ K Q J 8 6 4
♥ 9 2
♦ Q 8 7
♣ 9 4

♠ 5 2
♥ A 7 3
♦ K 10 4 3
♣ K J 6 2

West	North	East	South
Pass	2NT	2♠	Pass
Pass		Pass	3NT

All Pass

3NT by North

Lead: ♠K

Yes you should hold up. In fact you might as well hold up twice since you aren't contemplating a throw-in of East. Holding up twice will protect you in the unlikely event that East made his 2♠ bid with a 5-card suit.

Both the ♥ possibility and the ♣ possibility will either work or not, so you can save them for later. Your highest percentage chance is the fourth ♦, but here you must be careful. You must try to establish the ♦s without allowing East to get the lead. It is actually pretty easy. Just play a small ♦ from your hand and when East plays low insert the ♦10. West wins the ♦J but cannot harm you with his return.

When the remaining ♦s fall you have established your ninth trick.

Suppose East inkles out what you are trying to do and inserts his ♦Q when you play the low ♦ toward dummy?

If he does that he hands you all four ♦ tricks!

Partner's 1NT overcall shows 15-18 points and guarantees a ♠ stop. With 11 points and no 4-card ♥ suit you say 3NT.

The contract would be 3NT played by South.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♠K. Do you hold up or not?

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 3 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 8

You need just one more winner. It could come from a finesse of the ♣J. It could come from a 3-3 ♥ split. It could come by establishing a fourth card in ♦s.

Most important for now is the ♠ lead? Do you hold up?

Board 2

East Deals

N-S Vul

♠ J 9 8 6 4 3

♥ 7 5 2

♦ 6 2

♣ A Q

♠ 7

♥ Q J 9 6 3

♦ Q 8 4

♣ K 10 5 3

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A 10 2

♥ A 8

♦ A K 7 3

♣ 9 8 6 2

♠ K Q 5

♥ K 10 4

♦ J 10 9 5

♣ J 7 4

West

North

East

South

2♥

Pass

2♠

Pass

3♠

All Pass

3♠ by East

Lead: ♦J

you only counted one ♥ loser - that means you MUST ruff a ♥ in your hand.

Win the ♦ lead and play ♥A and another ♥ before you touch trumps.

After this there is nothing the defense can do to stop you ruffing one ♥ in your hand.

Just suppose for an instant that you had played ♠A and another.

South would have taken the second ♠, then pulled your last ♠. When the ♣ finesse failed you would make only 8 tricks.

Partner's 2♥ bid is a transfer; you respond 2♠.

Partner now bids 3♠.

Partner's 2♥ bid is a transfer; you respond 2♠.

Partner now bids 3♠.

Partner tells you that he has only invitational strength, but has at least 6 ♠s. The ♠s are fine by you, but with only 15 HCP you decide to pass.

East plays 3♠. South leads the ♦J. UhOh. Maybe you should have bid game.

Loser List: ♠ = ? : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 0 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = ?

If the ♠s are 2-2 there will be only one loser in that suit. And maybe the ♣ finesse will work.

Don't get too optimistic too early. If you play ♠A and another ♠ you could go down. Remember that

Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 7 4
 ♥ A 10 9 8
 ♦ Q J 10 8
 ♣ J 8 3

♠ K Q 8 6 3

♥ 6 2

♦ K 7 3

♣ K 6 2



♠ J 9 5 2
 ♥ Q J 5
 ♦ 9 2
 ♣ 10 9 7 4

♠ A 10

♥ K 7 4 3

♦ A 6 5 4

♣ A Q 5

West	North	East	South
			1NT
Pass	2♥	Pass	2♠
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			
3NT by South			
Lead: ♦ Q			
= 8			

With 12 points and a 5-card Major you transfer partner to that Major. You bid 2♥. Partner bids 2♠. Now what do say next?

With 12 points and a 5-card Major you transfer partner to that Major. You bid 2♥. Partner bids 2♠. Now what do say next?

You must insist on game, but since partner could have a doubleton ♠ you do so by bidding 3NT to give him the choice.

He chooses 3NT by passing.

The contract would be 3NT played by North.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♦ Q. Do you win the first trick or holdup?

Winner List: ♠ = 3 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 3 :: Total

A holdup wouldn't hurt you since West would retain the lead. But it probably wouldn't help you much either since you do have 2 stoppers in the suit. You obviously need to establish at least one more winner in ♠s so you won't have to depend on the ♥ A being with East. Need it be said that ♥s is the suit you are worried about and East is the Danger hand? Let's say you win the first trick with dummy's ♦ K.

Suppose you play ♠ A, then ♠ K Q. If they split 3-3 you will be soooo happy because you will make at least 10 tricks. But if East shows out on the third ♠ you will be pretty happy because you can give up a ♠ to West and still make at least 9 tricks. But if West shows out on the third ♠ you could be in deep trouble. You would have to give East the lead to establish an extra ♠ winner, and he might very well lead through your ♥ K.

There is a great safety play to protect against a 4-2 ♠ split. Play a low ♠ from dummy and finesse the ♠ 10. West may win with a doubleton ♠ J but you will still make the contract.

With this layout the safety play finesse actually works and you make an overtrick.

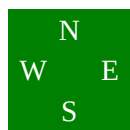
But visualize the ♠ J and ♠ 7 transposed. If you don't make the safety play it is true that the ♠ J will fall. BUT, East will still take the fourth ♠ and when he gets in he will return the ♥ Q.

Board 4

West Deals
Both Vul

♠ K J
♥ 10 9 7 3
♦ A K 5 3
♣ A Q 4

♠ A 6 2
♥ K J 8 5 2
♦ 9 8
♣ 10 7 3



♠ Q 10 9 8 4
♥ A 4
♦ Q 7 2
♣ 8 6 5

♠ 7 5 3
♥ Q 6
♦ J 10 6 4
♣ K J 9 2

West	North	East	South
1NT	Pass	2♥	Pass
2♠	Pass	2NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			
3NT by West			

Lead: ♥5

need will be ♠s. The danger is that when you force out the ♠A the defenders might be able to cash 4 ♥s right away. So the immediate decision is whether you take the ♥A on the first trick or wait until the second.

If North has only 4 ♥s it will make no difference what you do because they will only win 3 ♥ tricks and you will make your contract. So assume that North has a 5-card suit, which means that South has 2 ♥s. North's suit is definitely **NOT** ♥ K Q J 5 2; he would have started with the ♥K, not the ♥5. So you can be sure that South holds either ♥ K x, ♥ Q x or ♥ J x. So what?

So you should play the ♥A immediately. If South puts on his small ♥ then his lone honor will block the suit the next time it is played. But if he unblocks the honor under dummy's ♥A then your ♥ 10 9 7 will be promoted into a second stopper.

If you play low on the first trick South will win the ♥Q and return the ♥6 to dummy's ♥A. When North gains the lead with his ♠A he will cash 3 more ♥ tricks. Down 1.

Play the ♥A on the first trick and South is hog-tied. If he plays low the suit blocks, if he sacrifices his ♥Q then your ♥ 10 9 7 prevents North from running the suit.

Partner's 2♥ is a transfer, so you bid 2♠. Partner now bids 2NT.

Partner's 2♥ is a transfer, so you bid 2♠. Partner now bids 2NT.

Partner is only inviting, so he must have either 9 or 10 points. And since he chose 2NT as the invitation he must have only 5 ♠s. You will accept the invitation since you have a maximum 1NT opener, and you choose 3NT since you know there is no 8-card ♠ fit.

West plays 3NT. When North leads the ♥5 you have an immediate decision to make.

Winner List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 3 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 5

It is pretty clear that the 4 additional winners you need will be ♠s. The danger is that when you force out the ♠A the defenders might be able to cash 4 ♥s right away. So the immediate decision is whether you take the ♥A on the first trick or wait until the second.

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ Q J 4 2
♥ 8 3
♦ 9 8 3
♣ 10 8 6 5

♠ A 10 7 3

♥ 9 7

♦ K Q J

♣ K Q J 7



♠ 5

♥ K Q J 6 5 2

♦ A 6 4

♣ 9 4 3

♠ K 9 8 6

♥ A 10 4

♦ 10 7 5 2

♣ A 2

West	North	East	South
	1NT	2♥	2NT
Pass	3♣	Pass	3♥
Pass	3♠	Pass	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by North

Lead: ♥K

cue-bid following the lebensohl 2NT also promises a stopper in the enemy suit. In any case, partner replies 3♠. Next?

You bid 4♠.

The contract would be 4♠ played by South.

North plays 4♠. East leads the ♥K. Do you take the first trick or not?

Loser List: ♠ = 1/2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 3/4

You should not hold up on the ♥ for two reasons. First, West might have a singleton. Second, you might not have a ♥ loser at all (if you can discard both of dummy's ♥ losers on your ♣s).

So win the ♥A and start on trumps by playing ♠A, then ♠K. Uh Oh. West discards a ♥ on the second ♠ so you have two ♠ losers.

Now you will have to be lucky. Leave the two master trumps undrawn and start running the ♣s. Fortunately West has 4 ♣s and you are able to discard both of dummy's ♥ losers. Play a ♦ next and your luck continues when it is East who takes the trick. Since West can't get in to pull your trumps, you cannot be defeated. You play your ♦ winners and ruff a ♥ in dummy. West will get his two trumps at the end.

Imagine what would have happened if you had played a third trump.

West would have taken the two trump tricks, then East would have taken 5 ♥ tricks and the ♦A.

You need to find out if partner has 4 ♠s. Using lebensohl the way to do that is to first bid 2NT. Partner bids 2♣, the relay bid. What do say next?

You need to find out if partner has 4 ♠s. Using lebensohl the way to do that is to first bid 2NT. Partner bids 2♣, the relay bid. What do say next?

Now you cue-bid 3♥. An immediate cue-bid would have been Stayman, (for the other Major), but the cue-bid following the lebensohl 2NT also promises a stopper in the enemy suit. In any case, partner replies 3♠. Next?

You need to find out if partner has 4 ♠s. Using lebensohl the way to do that is to first bid 2NT. Partner bids 2♣, the relay bid. What do say next?

Now you cue-bid 3♥. An immediate cue-bid would have been Stayman, (for the other Major), but the cue-bid following the lebensohl 2NT also promises a stopper in the enemy suit. In any case, partner replies 3♠. Next?